Who Took My Pouch?

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Saltbush Story House

For every big sister and big brother,
and every baby who borrows their stuff.

Who Took My Pouch?
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Published by Saltbush Story House.
First edition, 2026.

Out where the grass grows tall and gold, there lives a little kangaroo called Clover.

Clover has the best thing in the whole wide bush.

Her mom's **POUCH**.

It's her bed. It's her ride. It's her snack bar. And it's **ALL** hers.

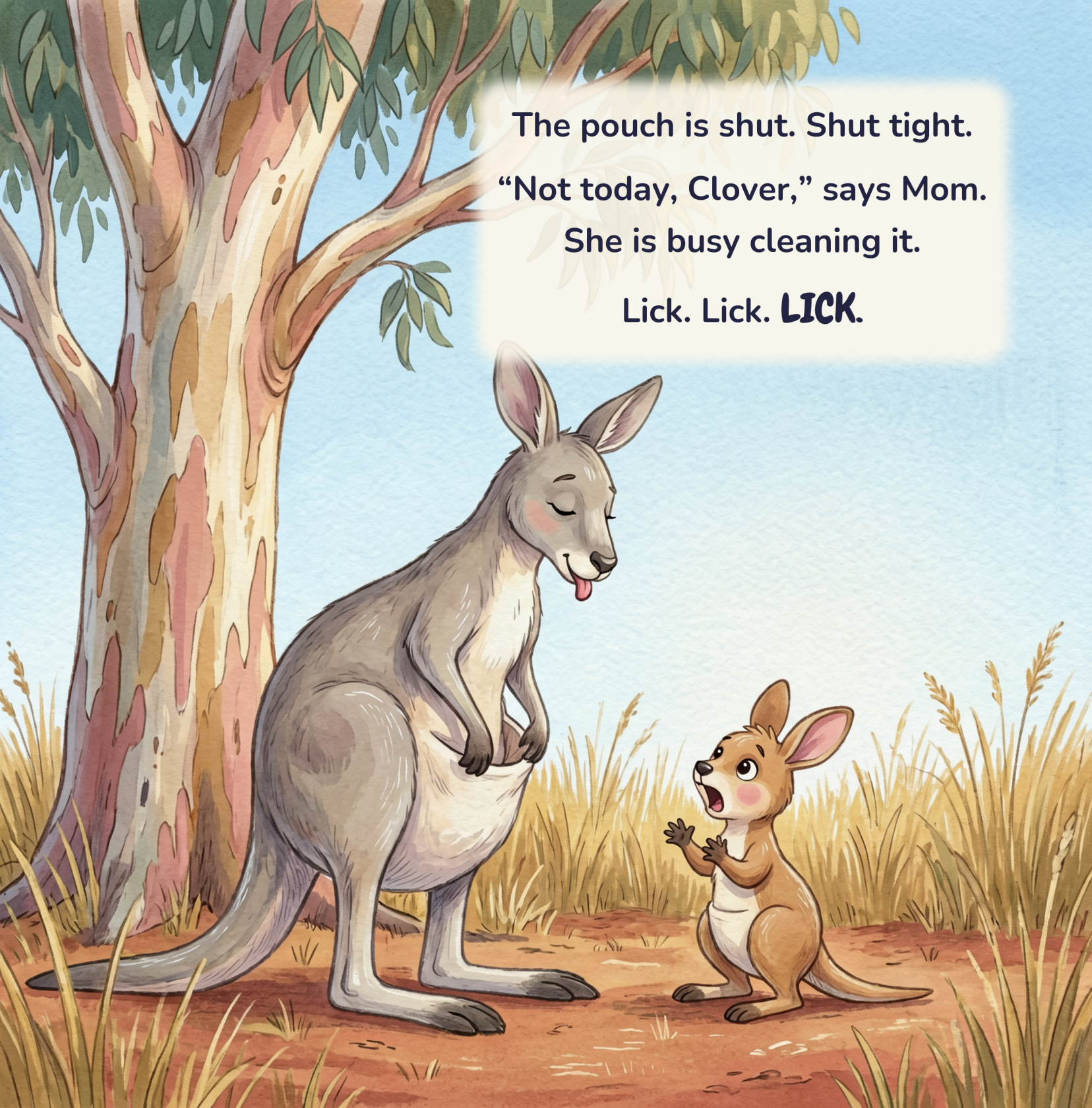
She naps in it.

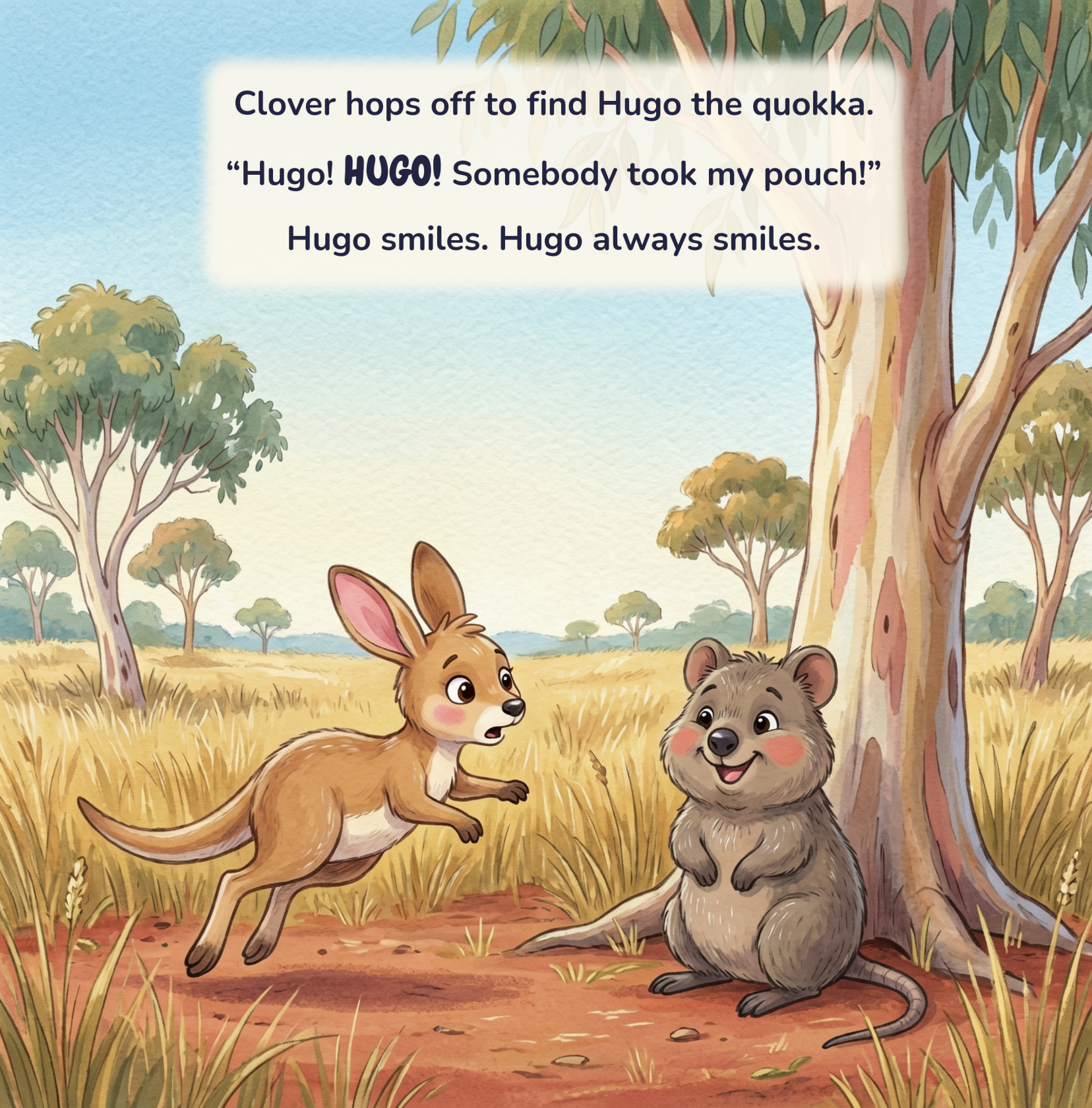
She snacks in it.

She rides in it, **BOING, BOING, BOING!**

One morning, Clover takes a big hop, a **BIGGER** hop, and dives for the pouch...

BONK!


The pouch is shut. Shut tight.
“Not today, Clover,” says Mom.
She is busy cleaning it.
Lick. Lick. LICK.


Clover hops off to find Hugo the quokka.
“Hugo! HUGO! Somebody took my pouch!”
Hugo smiles. Hugo always smiles.

“Pouches don’t just **SHUT**,” says Clover. “Somebody **TOOK** my pouch. And I’m going to find out who.”

Hugo smiles, and nibbles a leaf.

Under a log, somebody is digging. It's Wombat! And Wombat has a **POUCH**.

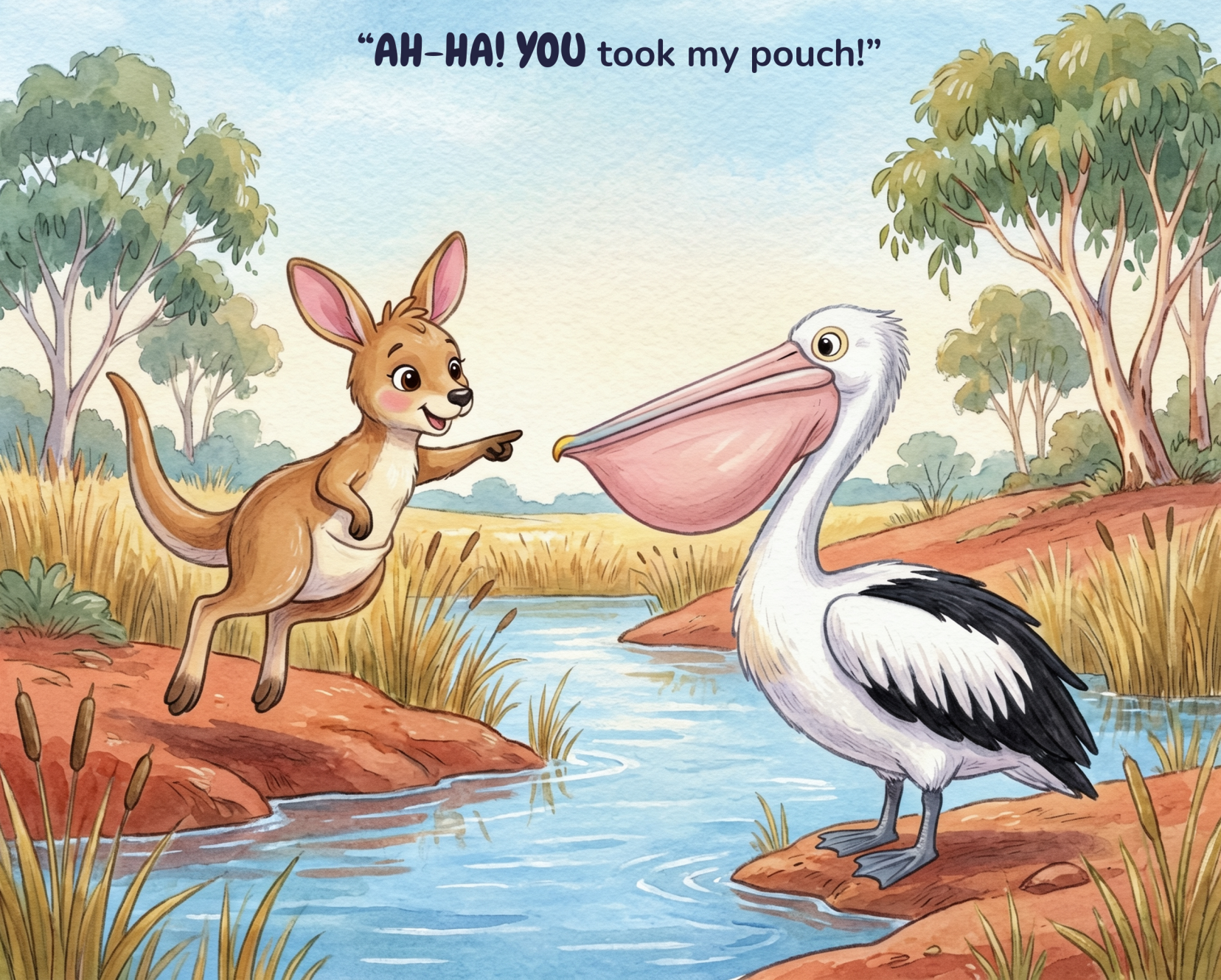
"Wombat! Did you take my pouch?"

“This old thing?” says Wombat. “Mine faces BACKWARD,
so I don’t get dirt on my baby.”
A tiny wombat waves.
“Sorry, Wombat.”

GULP!

Down at the waterhole, Pelican has a pouch. A **BIG** one.

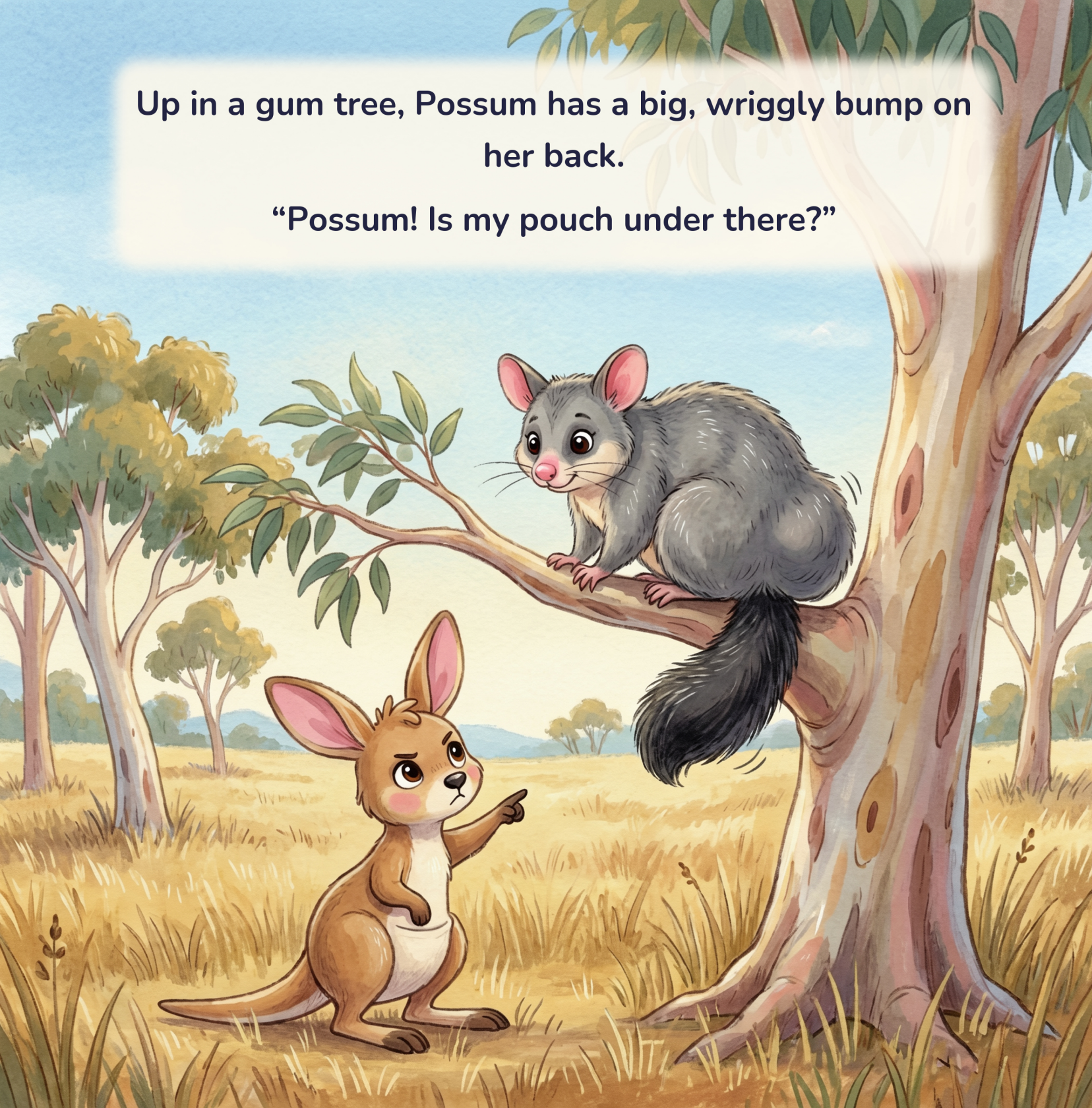
"**AH-HA! YOU** took my pouch!"



“This is my **BEAK** pouch,” says Pelican. “It’s for fish.”

SPLOOSH! Out jumps a fish.

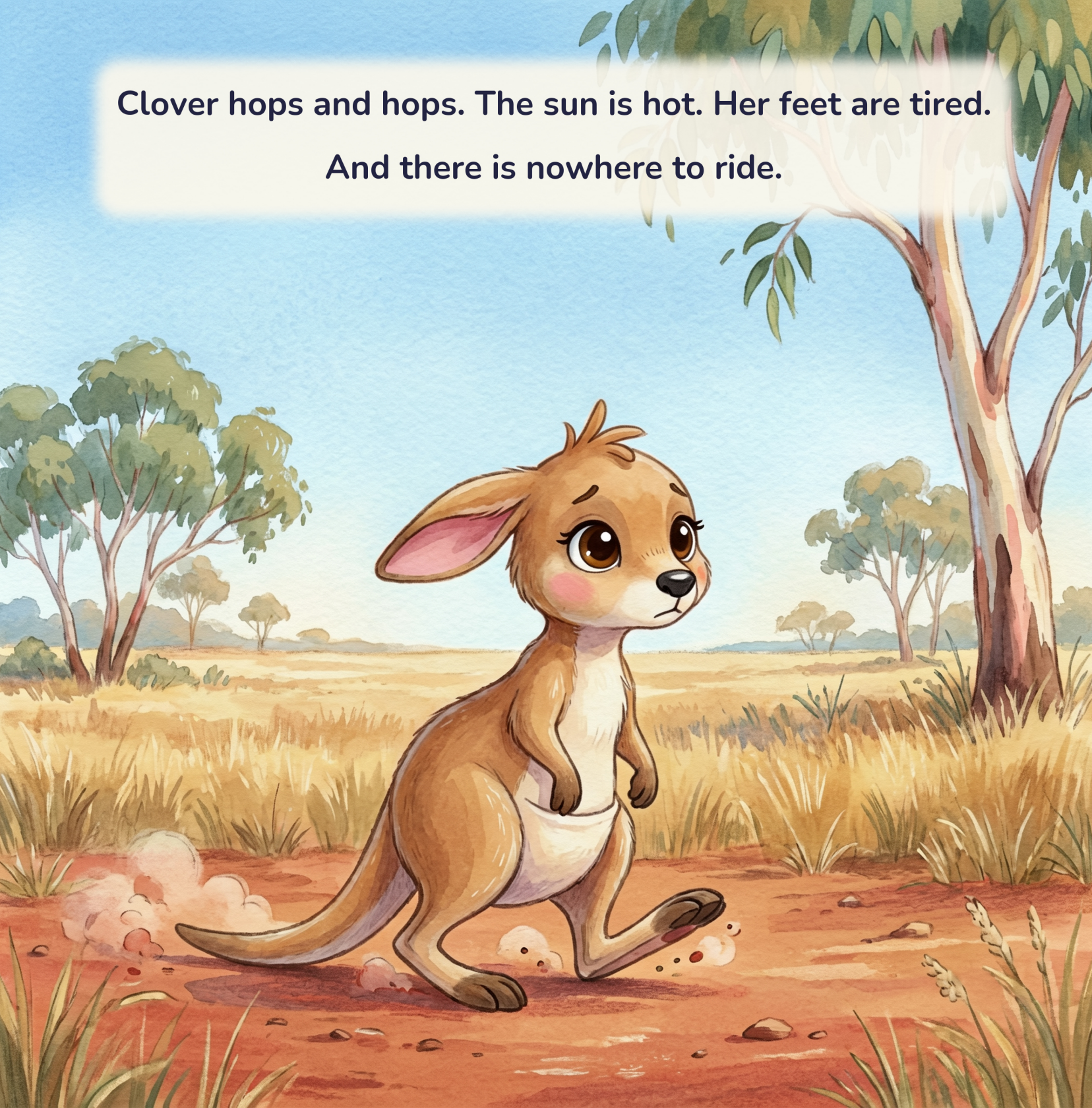
“Sorry, Pelican.”

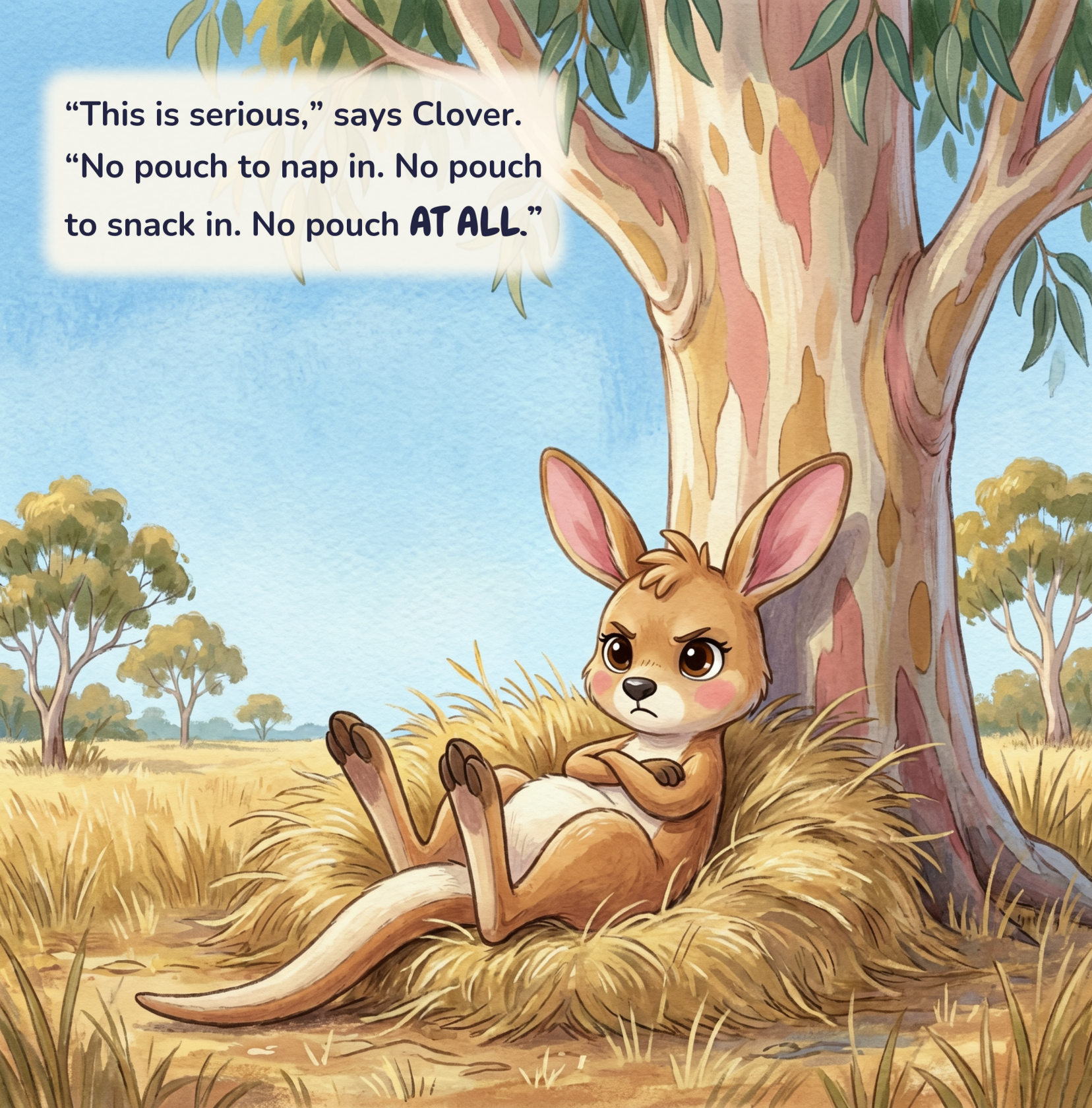

Up in a gum tree, Possum has a big, wriggly bump on her back.
“Possum! Is my pouch under there?”

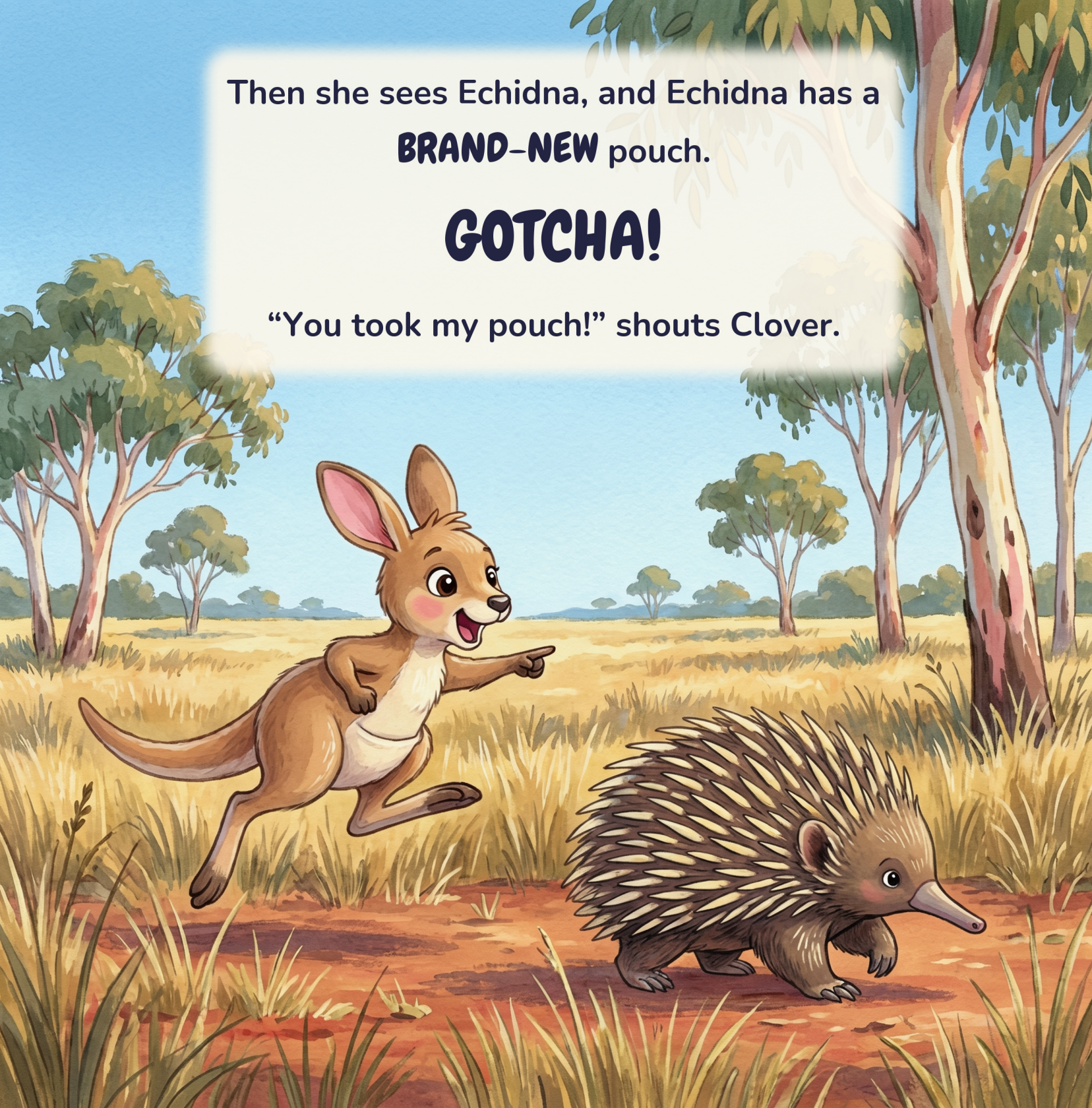
“That’s my baby,” says Possum. “She got too big for my pouch. Now she rides on my back.”

Too big for a pouch? Clover giggles. Nobody is too big for a pouch!

“Sorry, Possum.”


Clover hops and hops. The sun is hot. Her feet are tired.
And there is nowhere to ride.


“This is serious,” says Clover. “No pouch to nap in. No pouch to snack in. No pouch AT ALL.”

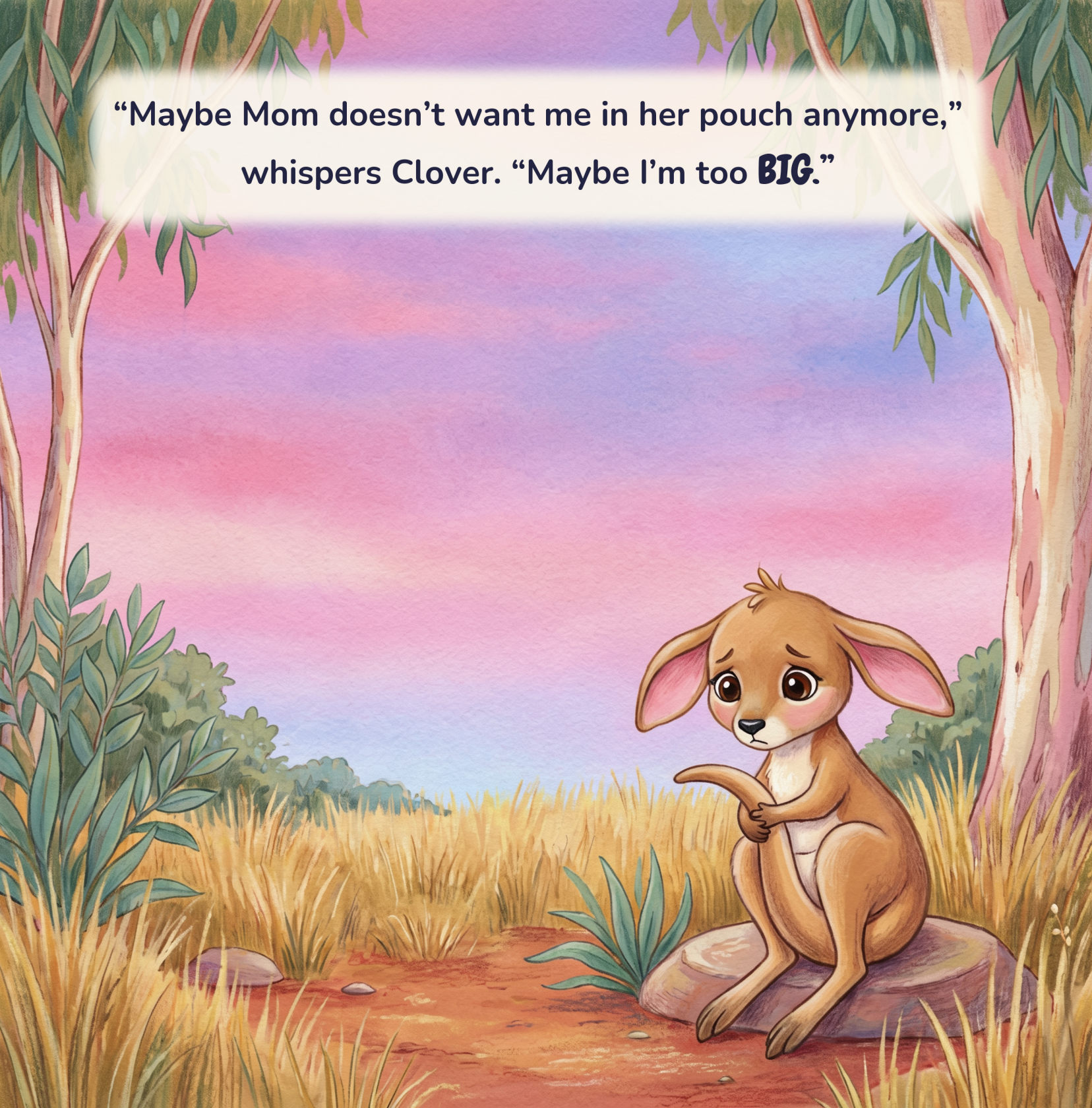

Then she sees Echidna, and Echidna has a BRAND-NEW pouch.
GOTCHA!
“You took my pouch!” shouts Clover.

“I grew my own,” says Echidna. “Just in time for my egg.”

A pouch for an egg?

Clover’s ears go up. Pouches are for... **BABIES?**

The sun goes down. The grass turns pink. Everybody is going home.


“Maybe Mom doesn’t want me in her pouch anymore,”
whispers Clover. “Maybe I’m too BIG.”

Hugo sits down next to her. He smiles his biggest smile.

“Nobody took your pouch,” he says. “Somebody **NEW** is in it.
Go and look.”

Mom opens the pouch, just a little.

Clover peeks inside.

There, tiny and pink, no bigger than a jellybean, is a brand-new **BABY**.

“A baby,” whispers Clover. “In **MY** pouch?”

“In **OUR** pouch,” says Mom. “You were that small once, too.” And she gives Clover the biggest hug a kangaroo can give.

Clover is too big for the pouch now. But she can hop over bushes.

She can race Hugo.

She can nap at Mom’s feet.

And she can still pop her head in for a drink.

The baby grows and grows. Everybody comes to visit:
Wombat, Pelican, Possum and Echidna.

Clover stands guard, very proud.

Then one morning, two little ears pop out of the pouch.
“Hello, baby,” says Clover. “I’m your BIG SISTER.”

That night, Clover curls up at Mom's feet under the stars.

"Good night, Mom. Good night, baby. Good night, our big, cozy, **CROWDED** pouch."

In the morning, Clover hops over to say hello.

The baby looks at Clover. The baby looks at the pouch.

“MINE!”

Hugo smiles.

True Facts from the Bush

Joeys. A newborn kangaroo is about the size of a jellybean. It crawls into its mom's pouch and stays there for months.

Out of the pouch. A joey leaves the pouch for good at about 8 to 10 months old, but it still pokes its head in to drink milk.

Two kinds of milk. A kangaroo mom can make two kinds of milk at once: one for her tiny baby and one for her big joey.

Spring cleaning. Before a new baby is born, a kangaroo mom licks her pouch clean.

Wombats have a backward-facing pouch, so no dirt gets in when they dig.

Pelicans scoop up fish and water in the pouch under their beak, then tip the water out.

Brushtail possum babies live in the pouch for about 4 to 5 months, then ride on mom's back.

Echidnas lay one soft egg and keep it in a pouch that forms on their tummy.

Quokkas are small wallabies. They have pouches too, and they always look like they're smiling.

About the Author

Hattie Moss writes funny picture books about Australian animals. She thinks kangaroo pouches are the coziest places in the whole bush.

Also by Hattie Moss: *Who Peeled My Tree?* and *Who Frosted My Tree?*

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